1). Which topic from the list did you choose? What steps have you taken so far to narrow it down? Describe how you've used tools like google news, academic encyclopedia, CQ researcher, EBSCO host, etc., and what keywords you've used so far.

None, I devised my own topic taking the course theme into account:

Topic (Not Concise): *"The Cinematic Suburbia"* - How a Reduction in Suburban Filming Locations (in Los Angeles, California) is Leading/Can Lead to a Worse Public Opinion on SoCal Suburban Cities and an Economic Downturn for Local Business Owners

I used Google Scholar to do a preliminary search on related materials to discover sources I could use naturally while reading about my topic.

Focus on economics – "baskets"

Focus on Hollywood – Labor, Inequality

Unions, bargain agreements (Hollywood as an Institution)

Suburbia (Corporate power from Hollywood -> Real Estate Development)

Politics ->

2). Who is affected by this problem? Try to identify the affected group as precisely as you can ("renters," "suburban residents," "homeless people," etc. are too broad – narrow it down!). How are they being affected, specifically?

Hollywood/SoCal-based film producers/directors AND related staff (i.e. film crew, actors, etc.), Local business owners in suburban areas of the Los Angeles County (i.e. Burbank, Santa Monica, Pasadena, Redondo Beach, Torrance, etc.).

3). Who/what appears* to be causing the problem? Are any policies or organizations (laws, court rulings, policies from government agencies, the military, police departments, school districts, housing authorities, unions, chambers of commerce, etc.) causing the problem, and/or making it worse? *It's best to keep an open mind at this point, as conventional wisdom may crumble in the face of in-depth research.

Specifically, the decrease in the number of filming permits in certain areas indicates this trend due to higher overall costs in SoCal regions.

4). When did this problem develop? Has it gotten worse in recent times? If so, when, and can you see any direct causes of that trend?

This problem developed in recent years following the COVID-19 pandemic and is continuing due to a lack of policy changes. Even now, these trends are discussed by popular news sources.

5). Where is this problem occurring? In addition to thinking about map geography (a part of Southern California, say), you should also be

thinking about a certain *kind* of place ("wealthy suburban enclaves," "majority minority 'ethnoburbs'," etc.) that exists more largely nationally and/or internationally.

I researched specifically the scope of SoCal but wealthy suburban areas nationally may also be affected in the U.S.

New York is one popular location to film instead of suburban areas that were once chosen.

The topic

Your topic area (from the Potential Research Topics list): I devised my own topic, but it falls under the broader category of *"Representation and Perception in Media"* related to urban and suburban spaces. It also has an interconnected to economics that can be discussed/researched further.

Your specific problem:

A reduction in suburban filming locations in Los Angeles County leads to worsening public perceptions of Southern California suburban cities and financial harm for local suburban business owners who rely on film production.

Your guiding research question:

How is the decline in filming permits and suburban filming locations in Los Angeles County affecting public perceptions of suburban communities and the local economies of suburban businesses dependent on film productions?

(Specific case studies can be researched as *evidence*)

Your tentative problem statement:

The decrease in suburban filming in Los Angeles County since the COVID-19 pandemic is harming both the cultural image of SoCal suburbs and the economic stability of local businesses that have traditionally benefited from the fame associated with film production activity. Rising costs and policy inaction have shifted film projects elsewhere, threatening SoCal's suburban economies and potentially fueling negative stereotypes of suburban communities due to less cinematic representation.

Key Questions: (answer these substantively – at least 200 words per question set)

Who is being harmed by your problem? What negative consequences, specifically, are they suffering?

The groups most directly harmed are Hollywood/SoCal-based film producers, directors, and the broader film industry workforce (including crew members, set designers, and actors) as well as local business owners in suburban communities across Los Angeles County, such as Burbank, Santa Monica, Pasadena, Redondo Beach, and Torrance.

For film industry professionals, fewer suburban filming locations mean fewer available projects, limited creative options, and increased logistical costs, which can threaten jobs and shrink budgets for smaller productions. For local businesses, the negative consequences are largely financial. Restaurants, cafes, hardware stores, boutique shops, prop rental businesses, and other services often earn significant income by hosting film crews, catering services, or renting space and materials for shoots. When filming relocates out of the region, these suburban businesses lose critical revenue streams.

Beyond the direct economic effects, there's also a cultural dimension: with fewer films showcasing these suburbs, public perceptions of SoCal suburban life risk becoming outdated or increasingly negative. Without new cinematic portrayals, the suburbs may appear stagnant, dull, or irrelevant, potentially reinforcing stereotypes about conformity and blandness rather than showing the diversity and vibrancy that actually exists in many of these communities.

Why does the problem exist? What events, laws, legal decisions, policies, etc. have led to the development of your problem?

Several overlapping factors have contributed to this problem. One major reason is the significant increase in the costs associated with filming in Los Angeles County, especially in suburban areas. Rising permit fees, insurance costs, location fees, and union labor costs have made suburban shooting financially prohibitive for many filmmakers, particularly independent productions.

Another crucial factor was the COVID-19 pandemic, which disrupted the film industry's logistical norms. Health regulations and social distancing requirements made suburban on-location shoots more expensive and complex, pushing productions toward controlled studio environments or other states and countries with looser regulations and lower costs.

Moreover, aggressive film tax incentives offered by other states, like Georgia and New York, have lured productions away from California. California has a tax credit program, but it's highly competitive and often focused on retaining large studio productions rather than smaller films that would traditionally use suburban streets and businesses as filming locations.

A lack of targeted policy interventions to protect suburban filming zones in LA County has left these communities particularly vulnerable. Despite the economic value that filming brings to suburban businesses and cities, no comprehensive policy has been enacted to reduce location costs, streamline permitting, or create incentives specifically for suburban filming.

How have they done so? (In other words, how have the factors contributing to this problem caused or exacerbated it, specifically? What are the dynamics that have aggravated the problem? This question is asking you to go beyond identifying the factors that have contributed to the problem by describing them in more detail.)

The financial pressures on filmmakers have created a strong push toward more affordable locations, either in states offering substantial tax breaks or in controlled studio spaces that eliminate many location costs. This has reduced demand for real suburban streets, homes, and commercial areas as filming backdrops.

When suburban filming decreases, local businesses lose both direct income and valuable indirect promotion. For instance, businesses that appear in films often gain increased foot traffic or tourism. Without that exposure, suburban economies grow more insular and less connected to broader cultural trends.

The pandemic accelerated this trend by forcing productions to seek safer, more controllable environments. Even after restrictions eased, many studios and producers discovered that shooting in other places—or relying more on digital effects and built sets—was cheaper and logistically simpler.

This ongoing shift has an additional cultural cost. Hollywood shapes public narratives, and if suburban communities no longer appear on screen, they risk fading from popular consciousness or being misrepresented. This fuels a feedback loop: as filming drops off, fewer stories are set in these suburbs, reducing their visibility and appeal, which in turn can lower tourism, business interest, and investment.

In essence, rising costs, policy inaction, and competitive incentives from other regions have compounded one another to squeeze suburban filming out of Los Angeles, threatening both economic health and cultural representation.

When: Create your own mini-timeline featuring at least 4 events that are either direct or indirect causes of your problem.

2014: California launches the Film & TV Tax Credit 2.0 program, but critics argue it favors big-budget projects, leaving many suburban-based productions unsupported.

2020: COVID-19 pandemic hits. Film production halts across Los Angeles County due to health mandates, increasing uncertainty and costs for location-based shoots, especially in suburban neighborhoods.

2021-2022: Other states, especially Georgia and New York, ramp up aggressive tax incentives for film production, drawing more projects away from California.

2023-2025: Industry reports and trade publications begin highlighting significant drops in suburban filming permits in LA County suburbs. Local business owners voice concerns about lost revenue and cultural visibility as suburban areas appear less frequently in new film and television releases.

Present: Policies are being pushed to fund the film industry in SoCal reported this past week.

Works Cited

List at least four sources that you plan to use in your rough draft.

Relevant sources which may be up to debate whether to be used or not.

Laura Pulido, Laura Barraclough, and Wendy Cheng, A People's Guide to Los Angeles (2012)

Film & TV Tax Credit 2.0 program

The Economics of Filmed Entertainment in the Digital Era

Pleasantville?: The Suburb and Its Representation in American Movies

Done Deal: California Greenlights $750 Million Infusion to Film and TV Tax Credit Program

City council approves proposal to help LA film production by reducing fees

Which source is most timely? How has it affected your understanding of the problem (useful information, new perspective, connection to historical antecedents, etc.)?

"Done Deal [. . .]" is the most timely being one of the most recent pieces of news from a popular source that highlight that policymakers see the SoCal film industry as vital to the economy. It showed me that my understanding of the problem should incorporate recent news in the upcoming weeks to sufficiently contextualize it.

Which source is most credible? How has it affected your understanding of the problem (useful information, new perspective, connection to historical antecedents, etc.)?

I feel any specific written legislation will be the most credible as it directly comes from, in this case, the California government. Existing legislation revealed to me that policies are constantly changing around the current state of my proposed problem.